History 315-3: The United States Since 1968
Fall Quarter 2024
TuTh 9:30-10:50, University Hall 121

Professor Michael J. Allen
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"What is important are the significant breaks—where old lines of thought are disrupted, older constellations displaced, and elements, old and new, are regrouped around a different set of premises and themes . . . The 1960s were a moment of break, but the regrouping around a different set of premises and themes was the work of the era that followed."

Daniel Rodgers, Age of Fracture

Description: This course examines the recent past that most US history courses never get around to discussing. The course surveys the rise and fall of market values--often called neoliberalism--in the United States (and around the world) over the past half-century to explain rising inequality, party polarization and political extremism, police violence and mass incarceration, the end of the Cold War and the War on Terror, and the election of Barack Obama and Donald Trump, two presidents who would have been unthinkable in 1968. It focuses on politics but also attends to society and culture. Along the way it considers the risks and rewards of studying the recent past, asking how history help us to understand and act in the present. The course ends with the collapse of the neoliberal order, which can be dated to the the global financial crisis in 2008 and the rise of Bernie Sanders and Donald Trump in 2016, along with challenges to the existing order around the world over the past decade or so. Prior collegiate or AP coursework in modern US and/or world history will be helpful to your understanding of course material but is not required so long as you are prepared to work hard and ask questions.

Learning Objectives (FD-HS):
In this course students will:

- Read, analyze, and evaluate primary source materials to become familiar with how diverse groups experienced and participated in political, social, and economic developments since 1968, and learn to use variation, repetition, consonance, and disagreement within such source materials to interrogate and explain change and continuity over time.
- Read, analyze, and evaluate varied secondary sources that offer scholarly interpretations of key questions in the history of the United States since 1968, thereby developing proficiency in historical argument, documentation, and debate.
- Engage in reasoned, respectful, evidence-based discussion and debate with other interpreters of history in verbal and written forms.
- Analyze, synthesize, and organize varied source materials into accurate and persuasive verbal and written arguments in answer to historical questions.
- Gain foundational knowledge of the political, social, cultural, intellectual, and technological forces that shaped life in the United States after 1968, and learn how they interacted across time and space to shape American and world history.

US Overlay Learning Objectives (US Perspectives on Power, Justice, and Equity):
In this course students will:

- Think critically about how structures of advantage and disadvantage changed after 1968, while identifying enduring patterns amid those changes.
- Consider how differences of race, ethnicity, religion, region, gender, sexuality, class, nation, and personhood were defined, contested, and changed after 1968 in relation to structures of power.
- Consider ways in which markets reinforced, restructured, and revolutionized structures of power, oppression, and hierarchy in the United States and around the world while exploring ways in which political and social movements organized in response to such changes, sometimes by joining, harnessing, and directing markets, sometimes by seeking their reform.
- Explore how practices, conditions, and ideologies of capitalism, nationalism, imperialism, patriarchy, and white supremacy motivated, influenced, undermined, or reinforced social, political, and economic relations, while also considering how market forces, imperatives, innovations, and logics reshaped such social relations.
- Reflect on their relationship to these processes and their position within these histories.

Responsibilities and Evaluation:

Class Participation: Regular attendance in class and thoughtful and informed contributions to class discussions will account for fifteen percent of your course grade. Class participation should reflect serious engagement with the reading, which should be completed before Thursday's class.

Students who attend all class meetings and regularly engage their peers in constructive and respectful ways, drawing on insights from the readings, will earn an "A" in class participation. Students who do these things often but not always will earn a "B." Those who do these things sporadically or seldom will earn a "C" or lower. Students are allowed three absences for any reason without penalty. Students who miss more than that without permission will see a grade reduction. If you must miss class due to extended illness or an emergency beyond your control you should let me know as soon as possible, ideally in advance, so that we can discuss alternate forms of participation.

Reading Responses: You will write four short essays responding to questions about the readings. Questions will be posted to Canvas by Saturday each week; essays should be 1-2 pages in length and must be submitted before class on Thursday, as these reflections are intended to prepare you for discussion. Late submissions will not be accepted or read. You may choose the weeks you wish to submit reading responses but must submit one within the first three weeks. Reading responses that offer a clear answer to the question supported by relevant evidence from the assigned reading and expressed in well-written, clearly reasoned prose will receive an A; those that struggle in one or more of these areas will receive a lower grade. Reading responses are worth twenty percent of your grade.

Textual Analysis: Using evidence and insights from course readings and lectures, you will produce an historical analysis of a movie, book, play, or TV series from the 1970s-80s, due at noon on Oct. 25. Your analysis can take the form of an essay of five to six pages or a recorded lecture with a written script of roughly similar length. Whatever format you choose, you must discuss course materials and themes from two or more weeks of the course. Further instructions, along with a list of potential sources, will be distributed early in the quarter, together with a grading rubric and examples. This assignment will be worth twenty-five percent of your course grade.

Election Analysis: Using evidence and insights from course readings and lectures, you will write an historical analysis of some dimension of the 2024 election, due at noon on Nov 27. Your analysis should be at least five and no more than seven pages long and must discuss course materials and themes from two or more weeks. It may incorporate outside research *but must not substitute that material for relevant assigned readings*. Students will present summary findings from this work to the class on Nov 21 or Nov 26. A brief proposal of what you plan to write and the materials you intend to include is due Nov 5. Your written analysis will be worth twenty-five percent of your course grade and your oral presentation will be worth an additional five percent.

Final Exam: A final exam on Dec 12 will account for the final ten percent of your course grade. It will feature a mix of multiple-choice questions and short identification questions and will serve to incentivize and reward full engagement with course readings and retention of course concepts. Exams will be administered in-person unless you have made other arrangements in advance.

Course Policies:

Guiding Principles: The discovery and the dissemination of knowledge that constitute the core purpose of higher education depend upon a collective pursuit of truths that can be demonstrated to fair-minded observers in verbal and written communication through reasoning from empirical evidence. It requires curiosity and an open mind, along with trust, transparency, and seriousness of purpose balanced against a healthy dose of skepticism and critical scrutiny. Striking this balance is difficult, but it is best achieved in engaged, respectful, and diverse communities where we can learn from, test, refine, and relay one another's thinking. The policies spelled out below are intended to foster those values and qualities in respect for our common purpose.

In-Person Learning: Community support and engagement is essential to your success as a student and future professional, and to our collective satisfaction and interest in our work. Your peers are an excellent source of advice, insight, practical and emotional support, and collegiality, now and into the future. For these reasons, I am committed to in-person learning and I expect students to attend lectures and discussions unless health considerations or personal emergencies make that ill-advised or impossible. I consider attendance as part of your participation grade and make recorded lectures available to students only when health or safety considerations require it.

Students are not granted permission to attend remotely except as the result of an Americans with Disabilities Act accommodation as determined and documented by AccessibleNU.

Covid Safety: The health and well-being of our community remains our highest priority. Should you test positive for COVID please follow CDC guidelines, which call for isolation until you have been fever-free for at least 24 hours without medications and advise masking for five days beyond that. If you are unable to attend class due to COVID symptoms, please notify course instructors.

Academic Integrity: Students in this course are required to comply with the policies found in the booklet, "Academic Integrity at Northwestern University: A Basic Guide." All papers submitted in this course must be submitted electronically as well as in hard copy, and will be screened for signs of plagiarized or AI-generated content. Cases of suspected academic dishonesty will be reported to the Dean's office. Any student found to have violated academic integrity standards will receive a failing grade for the assignment and may fail the course. For details regarding academic integrity at Northwestern or to download the guide, visit: https://www.northwestern.edu/provost/policies-procedures/academic-integrity/index.html.

Late Assignments: All coursework is due at the date and time specified so that all assignments can be read and evaluated at the same time using a single standard, and to ensure that students receive timely feedback on their work which can be applied in future assignments. Students should make every effort to complete assignments as scheduled. If that proves impossible due to unforeseen reasons beyond your control please notify me or your TA immediately and we will consider an extension. Work submitted late without an extension will be graded down by one letter grade; work more than a week overdue will not be accepted with my permission.

Electronics: Laptops and tablets can be useful to some students for notetaking but can also be distracting to their users and those around them. Students are discouraged from using them in class--lecture notes and slides will be posted to Canvas, making extensive notes unnecessary. If you feel you must use them in class, please sit in the last rows of the lecture hall and refrain from using them for anything but course-related purposes. The use of phones and earbuds is strictly prohibited.

Intellectual Property: All course materials are my intellectual property and not intended for distribution beyond this class. University policy states that "Unauthorized student recording of classroom or other academic activities (including advising sessions or office hours) is prohibited. Unauthorized recording is unethical and may also be a violation of University policy and state law. Students requesting the use of assistive technology as an accommodation should contact AccessibleNU. Unauthorized use of classroom recordings--including distributing or posting them--is also prohibited. Under the University's Copyright Policy, faculty own the copyright to instructional materials--including those resources created specifically for the purposes of instruction, such as syllabi, lectures and lecture notes, and presentations. Students cannot copy, reproduce, display or distribute these materials. Students who engage in unauthorized recording, unauthorized use of a recording or unauthorized distribution of instructional materials will be referred to the appropriate University office for follow-up."

Course Supports:

Accommodations: Northwestern is committed to providing an accessible learning environment for all students, and so am I. Should you anticipate or experience disability-related barriers to your success in this course or require accommodation related to a documented disability please speak

to the AccessibleNU office (accessiblenu@northwestern.edu; 847-467-5530) as soon as possible. If you have established accommodations with AccessibleNU, please let me know in the first week of the course so that we can work together to implement your disability accommodations. All such discussions will remain confidential.

Religious Observances: Students will not be penalized for class absences to observe religious holidays. If you will observe a religious holiday during a class meeting, scheduled exam, or assignment deadline, please let me know as soon as possible, preferably within the first two week of class. If exams or assignment deadlines on the syllabus fall on religious holidays you observe, please reach out so that we can discuss that coursework.

Well-Being: There are many stresses and strains associated with college and young adulthood. Please seek help if you need it. You can reach out to the following offices directly: www.northwestern.edu/counseling/; www.northwestern.edu/care/; www.northwestern.edu/religious-life/. See also: https://www.northwestern.edu/nuhelp/.

Writing Assistance: The History Writing Center, staffed by a graduate student in history, provides writing support at historywriting@northtwestern.edu and NU's Writing Place is also available in Main Library and at: www.writing.northwestern.edu.

Course Materials (available at online booksellers, Norris bookstore, and at NU Library):

Gary Gerstle, *The Rise and Fall of the Neoliberal Order: America and the World in the Free Market Era*, 2022.

Christine Walley, *Exit Zero: Family and Class in Postindustrial Chicago*, 2013.

All books are available digitally via NU Library; all shorter readings are available on Canvas.

Calendar:

Week 1: Introduction: We will review the syllabus, discuss course themes and expectations, and talk about how to get the most from the course. We will also review the governing ideas, institutions, and coalitions that structured American life before 1968.

Sept 24: Whatsoever Is True in a Post-Truth Age

Michael Allen, "On Reading History"

Academic Integrity: A Basic Guide

Sept 26: When Was America Great

Richard Nixon and Nikita Khruschev, "Kitchen Debate," 1959 (video/transcript)

Nancy MacLean, "The Rightness of Whiteness," 2006

Gary Gerstle, *Rise and Fall*, 1-47

Week 2: Age of Fracture: We consider how the liberal order that emerged in the 1930s collapsed amid war and racial conflict in the 1960s, yielding distrust and divisions that defined later decades.

Oct 1: Paint It Black

Oct 3: No Direction Home

Martin Luther King, Jr., "Beyond Vietnam," 4 April 1967 (audio/transcript)

"An Interview with Marriner Eccles," *Forbes*, 1968

Peter Davis, *Hearts and Minds*, 1974

Jimmy Carter, Crisis of Confidence Speech, 1979 (video)

Gary Gerstle, *Rise and Fall*, 48-69, 95-106

Week 3: Best of Times, Worst of Times: Week three focuses on the 1970s, when Americans lurched toward new political and economic arrangements in the face of successive challenges. These configurations were new but not random; they were predicated on existing patterns of inequality.

Oct 8: Rustbelt

Oct 10: Sunbelt

"'Welfare Queen' Becomes an Issue in Reagan Campaign," *NYT*, 15 Feb 1976
Timothy Moy, "Culture, Technology, and the Cult of Tech in the 1970s," 2004
Christine Walley, *Exit Zero*, 1-24, 57-88
Gary Gerstle, *Rise and Fall*, 107-121

Week 4: Back to the Future: This week examines the resurgence of free-market ideals in the 1980s. We continue to attend to the relationship between changing economic fortunes and long-standing racial, social, and cultural divides

Oct 15: Reagan Revolution

Oct 17: Market Forces

Ronald Reagan, First Inaugural Address, 1981
William Greider, "The Education of David Stockman," *Atlantic*, Dec 1981
Lee Atwater, "The South in 1984," March 1983
Heather Ann Thompson, "Why Mass Incarceration Matters: Rethinking Crisis, Decline, and Transformation in Postwar American History," *JAH*, Dec 2010
Christine Walley, *Exit Zero*, 89-116
Gary Gerstle, *Rise and Fall*, 121-140

Week 5: War Culture: Among Reagan's most celebrated achievements was "winning" the Cold War and restoring American greatness. We'll discuss those developments this week, using them to consider how the revolutions of the 1960s inspired the wars of the Reagan/Bush era.

Oct 22: Cold War

Oct 24: Culture War

Peggy Noonan, "That's Not Off My Disk," from *What I Saw At The Revolution*, 1990
Pat Buchanan, RNC Speech, 17 Aug 1992 (video)
Donna Murch, "Crack in Los Angeles: Crisis, Militarization, and Black Response to the Late Twentieth-Century War on Drugs," *JAH*, June 2015
Michael Sherry, "Moral Equivalents of War," 1995, 445-482
Gary Gerstle, *Rise and Fall*, 141-152

Week 6: Bridge to Tomorrow: How should we think about the 1990s? Do we focus on the decade's fierce partisanship or attend to the free-market policies promoted by both parties and embraced by most Americans? And where do the Clintons fit?

Oct 29: Triangulation

Oct 31: Clinton Wars

Barbara Ehrenreich, "Spinning the Poor Into Gold," *Harper's*, Aug 1997
Douglas Massey, "A Wrench in the Works," 2002
Christine Walley, *Exit Zero*, 129-143
Gary Gerstle, *Rise and Fall*, 152-188

Week 7: Forever War: We revisit the war on terror, tracing its roots back to the 1970s, exploring how it marked the end of Reaganism and the beginning of something more militant still.

Nov 5: Purity of Essence (Election Day)

Nov 7: Election Reflections

Ron Suskind, "Without a Doubt," *NYT Magazine*, 17 Oct 2004
Toby Craig Jones, "America, Oil, and War in the Middle East," *JAH*, June 2012
Joseph Stieb, "Moral Clarity: Terrorism, the Culture Wars, and Modern US Conservatism," *DH*, Sept 2022
Gary Gerstle, *Rise and Fall*, 189-210

Week 8: Dead End: We revisit 2006-10 as a moment of systemic crisis when the political and social order that emerged with Nixon broke down and was reassembled in new ways.

Nov 12: System Failure

Nov 14: Obamanation

Barack Obama, "A More Perfect Union," 18 March 2008 (video)
George W. Bush, "Address to the Nation on the National Economy," 24 Sept 2008 (video)
Mitt Romney, "Let Detroit Go Bankrupt," *NYT*, 18 Nov 2008
Tim Borstelmann, "More and Less Equal Since the 1970s," 2013
Christine Walley, *Exit Zero*, 153-168
Gary Gerstle, *Rise and Fall*, 210-260

Week 9: American Carnage: In our final week we ask how the neoliberal consensus that dominated the past half-century informs the crisis of the present and ponder what might follow it.

Nov 19: Speaking Bitterness

Devin Singh, "Covid-19 is Exposing Market Fundamentalism's Many Moral and Practical Flaws," *WP*, 10 April 2020
George Packer, "How America Fractured into Four Parts," *Atlantic*, July/Aug 2021
Jonathan Haidt, "Why the Past Ten Years of American Life Have Been Uniquely Stupid," *Atlantic*, May 2022
Gary Gerstle, *Rise and Fall*, 260-293

Nov 21: Student Presentations, 9:00-10:50

Week 10: Welcome to Wherever We Are: In our final meeting we will continue to reflect on the history of the present and ponder what is to come.

Nov 26: Student Presentations, 9:00-10:50

Nov 27: Election Papers Due, 12:00 PM

Nov 28: Thanksgiving--class does not meet

Finals Week:

Dec 12: Final Exam, 12:00-2:00

Staff:

Michael J. Allen **Hours: Mon 3-5:30** **m-allen1@northwestern.edu**

I was born in Arkansas in 1974 and I grew up poor in rural Kansas. My parents divorced when I was three and both remarried soon after, with my mother then divorcing and remarrying again before I was eight. My mom worked as a secretary but struggled to keep a job due to frequent moves, abusive men, inadequate childcare, and mental health struggles. She married her current husband, a car salesman, in 1982. They are now retired in the Florida panhandle. My father worked in the oil fields of western Kansas with stints in meatpacking when the price of oil fell. He quit the oil patch in the late 1990s to

become an overnight shelf stocker at Wal-Mart before retiring last year in his mid-70s. My stepmom waited tables and tended bar most of her life. None of my parents ever made much money or had stable work, which meant frequent moves for me and my sister, half-sisters, stepsisters, and stepbrothers. Our utilities were sometimes cut-off due to unpaid bills, and we often relied on public aid and private charity to survive.

My mother and stepfather are Pentecostal Christians, and I was raised in a world of water baptism, faith healing, speaking in tongues, spirit slaying, premillennialism, tent revivals, and Christian rock. We attended church twice on Sunday and every Wednesday, along with daily bible study, church camp, and TV evangelism. Like most white evangelicals, my parents are conservatives. My siblings have largely followed in their footsteps. My stepbrothers did so literally, working in the oil patch, with my younger stepbrother serving time in prison before he died from substance abuse in 2010. My high school best friend died the same way in 2011.

As I completed high school I applied to and was accepted by the University of Chicago, which I attended with financial aid, work-study, and federal loans, along with summer jobs. I then earned my PhD at Northwestern in 2003 and became an assistant professor at North Carolina State University. I was the first in my family to graduate college and am the only one to attain an advanced degree. I returned to join the faculty at Northwestern in 2008. My wife works as a university administrator and we live in Evanston with our daughter while our son attends college.

My research and teaching focus on American politics, particularly the ways in which war, violence, and empire shaped and reshaped political thought and culture. I am currently writing a book titled *The Center Ring: The Making and Breaking of the Liberal Presidency*, which treats the relationship between liberal reformers and presidential power from World War II through the Vietnam War. My first book *Until the Last Man Comes Home: POWs, MIAs, and the Unending Vietnam War* explored how Americans responded to defeat in Vietnam through POW/MIA activism and argues that wartime loss helped alienate white working people from the political left and the American government.

I have gone on at length about my biography for three reasons. First, my life reflects key developments in the period covered in this course, years roughly coterminous with my life: The struggles of the working-class; the decline of the postwar nuclear family and the male breadwinner ideal, especially on the bottom rungs of the economic ladder; the rise of the political right and the religious right; and the educational meritocracy that offered new modes of social mobility for some while closing off opportunities to others. My personal connection to these matters is one reason I teach this course, and informs how I approach this history.

Second, I mean to explain my perspective on these and other developments discussed in this course. My history has left me straddling many of the divisions that define American life, with feet planted on both sides of the rural/urban, red/blue, devout/secular, populist/elite, binaries that we use to organize contemporary society and politics. In this I am not alone. Most of us represent history's complexities in different ways, and I do not pretend to know personally everything we'll be discussing in this course. Indeed, there are many essential dimensions of the recent past that I can grasp only through historical study, which is one reason I enjoy reading, writing, and teaching history. But my life trajectory has made me a critical yet sympathetic observer of both my past and present communities, and the nation as a whole. By sharing something of my personal history, I hope to give you insight into where I am coming from in my approach to the recent past. We all come from different places, which is why we can learn from each other.

Third and finally, I want to convey to you that I have direct knowledge of the life-changing power of universities tempered by a sense of how many of us struggle, often invisibly, to feel at home in them. That experience means that I take what we do here seriously, and I hope you do too. However you arrived at Northwestern, all of us are privileged to be here and all of us should feel an obligation to make the most of our opportunity to grapple with big questions and master new skills. But that does not mean we won't find that work difficult. If you feel overwhelmed, I want you to know that I've felt that way too. If you need help, please don't be afraid to ask.